Threads of Severance

Narrative Design Document

Lillian Russell

Threads of Severance

Logline: In a world where romantic relationships are magically bound and affect reality itself, a young Temple Resonant named Joal is tasked with overseeing a high profile Severing ritual as emotional instability spreads. When the ritual fails, Joal uncovers a hidden cosmic fracture tied to the origins of the world and must choose between enforcing control or confronting emotional truth.

Tagline: You cannot sever what you refuse to face.

Genre: High Fantasy + Paranormal + Breakup

Synopsis: *Threads of Severance* takes place in a world where love is metaphysical, and relationships are magically bound through sacred rituals. When bonds begin to fail, emotional instability manifests as hauntings, shared dreams, and spiritual distortions. As these events increase across the continent, the Temple insists the issue is individual failure rather than a larger problem.

Joal, a disciplined Temple Resonant, is assigned to oversee a high profile Severing between two influential figures whose fractured bond is an entire district. While preparing the ritual, Joal discovers during astral projection that the couple's bond is entangled with something vast and unnatural. The Severing attempt fails, unleashing a violent Echo and spreading instability throughout the city.

Seeking answers, Joal turns to Keith, a Shardbound outsider who claims the Temple's practices are worsening the problem. Through hidden records and astral exploration, Joal learns that the world's instability stems from the forced Severing of a cosmic bond known as the Prime Bond. The couple's situation is not isolated, but a symptom of this deeper fracture.

In the final act, as the couple's instability begins affecting others, Joal rejects forced intervention and instead demands complete emotional honesty. The couple confronts their incompatibility and they mutually agree to separate, resulting in a clean Severing that stabilizes the district without creating further damage.

Table of Contents

Table of Contents
Introduction
1. Overview
    1.1. High-Level Concept and Franchise Positioning
        Genre X+Ys
        Closest Competitors
            His Dark Materials
            The Stormlight Archive
            Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind
    1.2. Theme
    1.3. Storyworld Aesthetic
2. The Storyworld
    2.1. Central Deviation from Reality
    2.2. Rules
        What's Possible
        What It Costs
        What's Not Possible
    2.3. Unique Verbs/Actions
        Project
        Bind
        Manifest
        Sever
        Reconcile
    2.4. Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs
        Basic Needs: Physiological
            Food
            Water
            Transport
            Reproduction
        Basic Needs: Safety
            Shelter
            Clothing
            Offense
            Defense
        Psychological Needs: Belongingness and Love
            Religion/Beliefs

        Community
        Family
        Government
    Psychological Needs: Esteem
        Social Classes
        Economics
        Government Tiers
    Self-Fulfillment Needs: Arts + Cultures
        Visual Arts
        Language and Literature
        Music
        Gameplay
    Self-Fulfillment Needs: Self-Actualization
        Mastery
2.5. Map
    Key Locations
        The City of Lumenreach (known to many as “The Threaded City”)
            Features/Characteristics
        The Verdant Vale (aka the “Heartlands of Harmony”)
            Features/Characteristics
        The Shattered Expanse (aka “The Severed Scar”)
            Features/Characteristics
    Here There Be Dragons locations
        The Sleepless Sea
            Features/Characteristics
        The Glasswood
            Features/Characteristics
        The Unmoored Plateau
            Features/Characteristics
2.6. Timeline
    The Hidden Timeline (known as the Restricted Archives)
2.7. Character Types
    Temple Resonants (Clerics of Binding)
        Abilities
        Beliefs
        Physical Characteristics
    Vale Harmonists (Agrarian Bond Keepers)
        Abilities
        Beliefs

Physical Characteristics
Shardbound (inhabitants of the Shattered Expanse)
Abilities
Beliefs
Physical Characteristics
Character Type Relationship Chart
3. The Story
3.1. Simple-Story
Setup
Act I
Act II
Act III
3.2. Super-Story
Part One
Part Two
Part Three
The End
3.3. Side-Stories
The Echo Keeper
The Binding Season
The Failed Severing
4. Heroes
4.1. Joal
Background
Personality
Desires
Abilities
Weaknesses
Arc
5. Villains
5.1. Astrael (ASS-TRAY-EL)
Background
Personality
Desires
Abilities
Weaknesses
Arc
5.2. Lost
Background

Personality
Desires
Abilities
Weaknesses
Arc
6. Allies
6.1. Keith (KEY-TH)
Background
Personality
Desires
Abilities
Weaknesses
Arc
6.2. Mendalie (MEN-DUH-LEE)
Background
Personality
Desires
Abilities
Weaknesses
Arc
6.3. Inishi (E-NEE-SHE)
Background
Personality
Desires
Abilities
Weaknesses
Arc
7. Organizations
7.1. The Temple of Binding(Temple Resonants)
7.2. The Verdant Concord(Vale Harmonists)
7.3. The Shardbound Clans(Shardbound)
8. Places
8.1. Lumenreach (The Threaded City)
Environment and Aesthetic
Key Features/Locations
Narrative Function
8.2. The Verdant Vale (Heartlands of Harmony)
Environment and Aesthetic
Key Features/Locations

Narrative Function
8.3. The Shattered Expanse (The Severed Scar)
Environment and Aesthetic
Key Features/Locations
Narrative Function
9. Artifacts
9.1. Notable Weapons
Threadbreaker Blade
Resonance Bow
Echo Lantern
9.2. Notable Wearables
Threadwoven Cloaks
Anchor Rings
Shardbound Veil
9.3. Items
Memory Vials
Echo Seeds
9.4. Vehicles
Caravans of Tetherlight
10. Enemies
10.1. Resonance Demons
Behavior
Abilities
Weaknesses
Narrative Function
10.2. Echo Wraiths
Behavior
Abilities
Weaknesses
Narrative Function
10.3. Dream Drifters
Behavior
Abilities
Weaknesses
Narrative Function
11. Sample Reference Materials
11.1. Games
Gris
Journey

Spiritfarer
Hellblade
11.2. Movies
Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind
Annihilation
The Fountain
11.3. Television
The Leftovers
Black Mirror
Arcane
11.4. Books
His Dark Materials
The Night Circus
The Stormlight Archive
11.5. Comics
Saga
Sandman
11.6. Music
Carrie and Lowell
Melodrama
NieR: Automata Soundtrack
About the Author

Introduction

This story bible is intended as a guide to the *[Title]* franchise as it is currently developed. This document is designed to provide useful reference and resource material for the future possible development of this intellectual property (IP) as a transmedia experience that flows across multiple entertainment platforms.

Much of this IP could work well in a single medium – particularly a serialized medium such as books, comics or television – but this IP is specifically designed to lend itself to creation and distribution as a transmedia story. The later parts of this document describe one possible transmedia development strategy. This document is designed to assist creative partners working together on such distributed creation and development in creating a total franchise experience that is greater than the sum of its parts.

Note 1: there are fiction elements in this story bible unintended for inclusion in the initial *[Title]* story, but are instead meant to be revealed across multiple elements of the franchise over multiple years.

Note 2: this document includes multiple illustrations, but these are not meant to indicate any final artwork. The imagery and photography included here are only done so as gestural references, pointing towards possible directions of development or the general intended tone.

1. Overview

1.1. High-Level Concept and Franchise Positioning

Genre X+Ys

Genre X: Breakup

Genre Y: Paranormal

Genre Z: High fantasy

Uniqueness: A high fantasy world where souls can partially leave their bodies and relationships are magically registered at temples (like marriage). When two people begin to grow emotionally incompatible, supernatural phenomena start to occur, such as hauntings, poltergeists, and shared dreams, which forces people to confront their own separation before it harms them.

Closest Competitors

His Dark Materials

Genre X: Coming of age

Genre Y: Metaphysical fantasy

Genre Z: High fantasy

Uniqueness: Human souls exist outside the body as daemons, externalizing inner emotional and psychological states. Romantic and emotional separation has physical and spiritual consequences

Aspects to Emulate: Treating emotional bonds as spiritually and cosmologically important. Emotional development used as a central narrative theme rather than a subplot. Clear and consistent metaphysical rules that are more inevitable than they are random.

Opportunities for Improvement: Romantic relationships are explored a lot less deeply than familial bonds. Emotional incompatibility is often more abstract rather than situational or relational. Consequences are more symbolic than systemic.

The Stormlight Archive

Genre X: Character drama

Genre Y: Supernatural

Genre Z: High fantasy

Uniqueness: Magic systems are powered by bonds between humans and spren, which reflect internal ideals, mental health, and moral commitments. Emotional states directly affect access to power.

Aspects to Emulate: Highly structured systems with understandable cause and effect. Emotional struggles that meaningfully impact the world's mechanics. Character arcs that reward emotional growth.

Opportunities for Improvement: Emotional conflict often serves for story progression and not relational depth. Interpersonal relationships are second to individual development. Large scale stakes can drown out the intimate and emotional moments.

Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind

Genre X: Breakup

Genre Y: Paranormal

Uniqueness: Breakups are explored through surreal, memory altering technology that transforms emotional pain into a literal internal landscape.

Aspects to Emulate: Surrealism used to mimic psychological experience. Willingness to let emotional discomfort drive the narrative structure.

Opportunities for Improvement: The worldbuilding remains intentionally vague and isn't systematic. Supernatural elements function more metaphorically than they do physically. They don't explore the wider picture of society and the implications of the systems.

1.2. Theme

At the heart of this world is the idea that emotional truth is inevitable. Relationships are not private, abstract experiences, but rather metaphysical forces that shape reality itself. When two people bind their souls, their emotional alignment becomes structurally embedded in the fabric of the world. Love that is mutual and honest produces harmony, stability, and shared strength. But when compatibility is denied or suppressed, the fracture doesn't remain contained. It manifests itself as hauntings, distortions, Echoes, and spiritual instability. They are the natural consequences of emotional dishonesty.

This world enforces the fact that love cannot be manufactured, control cannot replace resonance, and avoidance only deepens fracture. Confrontation, vulnerability, and mutual acknowledgement are the only paths to either reconciliation or clean separation. In a society where bonds are visible and registered, the tension between public commitment and private truth becomes central. Ultimately, the theme explores the difference between attachment and alignment, arguing that harmony isn't something achieved once and forgotten about, but something continuously maintained through emotional courage.

1.3. Storyworld Aesthetic



https://medium.com/@dancrean/my-vacation-on-the-astral-plane-f7ba65cfb853

I chose this image because it represents the astral plane people enter when their souls leave their body



https://medium.com/@NorthStarLight/embarking-on-a-journey-beyond-exploring-astral-projection-and-the-out-of-body-experience-eaefef77a73d

I chose this image because it represents one's soul leaving their body and entering the astral plane and how it happens



https://bat-smg.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abruozdielis:Iglesia_de_La_Compa%C3%B1%C3%ADa,_Quito,_Ecuador,_2015-07-22,_DD_149-151_HDR.JPG

What a church for registering relationships might look like



https://www.reddit.com/r/wallpaper/comments/3jhbjr/art_landscape_fantasy_world_rocks_1280_1024/

How natural landscape would look



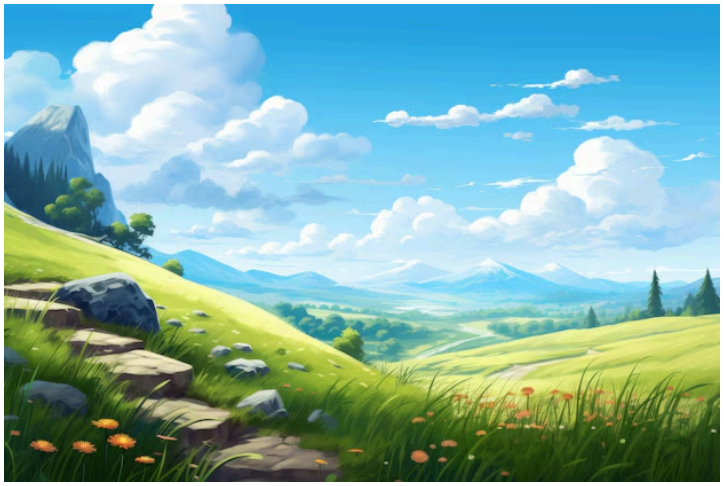
https://robinpiree.com/blog/fantasy-city-ideas?srsltid=AfmBOoo6bXW0iZlwcZVQTI3fqlbG8OQV_TszjUo6m8MBP9ZXvP5Jrebc

Kingdom aesthetic



https://stock.adobe.com/search?k=fantasy+city&asset_id=811998757

This is what a bustling town would look like from the inside



https://www.freepik.com/premium-ai-image/fantasy-green-rolling-hills-landscape_152637863.htm

Rolling hills



https://wall.alphacoders.com/big.php?i=1306137

More calm and peaceful scenic views



https://www.dreamstime.com/photos-images/vibrant-fantasy-creatures.html

Monsters and creatures(some evil and some peaceful)



The demon lands where the demon lord and her subjects stay

https://tabletopterrain.com/cdn/shop/files/DALL_E_2024-07-09_13.13.21_-_A_wide-screen_banner_image_depicting_an_evil_fantasy_landscape._The_scene_features_a_desolate_twisted_landscape_with_dark_jagged_mountains_under_a_s.webp?v=1740505764&width=1400

2. The Storyworld

2.1. Central Deviation from Reality

What if relationships were magical and had different effects depending on the state of the relationship?

2.2. Rules

This high fantasy world allows for detaching one's soul from their body, which causes it to exist as a spiritual double in the astral plane. Romantic relationships are magically formalized at temples/churches through a ritual called "Binding", which ties two souls together. This isn't permanent, but certainly is resistant to breaking. When two people who are bound begin to grow emotionally incompatible, their souls don't separate cleanly, but rather the instability in their bond produces supernatural phenomena. The world itself reacts to relational fracture.

What's Possible

Souls are able to leave the body under certain conditions such as sleep, emotional distress, or a sort of ritual practice.

Temples can magically register relationships through binding rituals, which creates a visible mark and spiritual tether between partners.

Nearly any paranormal type phenomena can happen in the world when one's heart experiences strong negative emotions (typically in relation to the person's relationship, but rare circumstances can change that).

Skilled clerics or soul-mages can stabilize, examine, or weaken a bond.

A bond can be dissolved, but only through confrontation, mutual acknowledgment, or an official Severing ritual.

The magic in this world is reactive, not controllable. It responds to emotional truth rather than conscious intention.

What It Costs

Soul projection is physically exhausting. The farther the soul drifts, the weaker the body becomes. Prolonged separation can cause fever, memory gaps, or temporary loss of sensation.

Ignoring incompatibility intensifies manifestations. Minor cold spots could turn into violent hauntings.

If one partner refuses to acknowledge the fracture, the other may suffer "soul drag", where their spirit is partially pulled toward the resistant partner.

Temple Severing rituals are emotionally and spiritually painful. Participants must relive the relationship's defining memories in accelerated visions.

If a bond is forcibly severed without emotional truth, fragments of the connection remain as lingering spirits called Echoes, which are semi-conscious remnants that haunt future relationships.

Being publicly Severed carries stigma. It's seen as a spiritual failure.

What's Not Possible

One partner cannot unilaterally erase a bond without consequence. Attempting to do so causes severe spiritual backlash.

Love cannot be artificially created through Binding. The ritual amplifies what already exists. It does not create emotion.

A person cannot be bound to more than one living partner at a time. Attempting multiple bindings causes soul fragmentation.

Temples can't prevent incompatibility from forming. They can only reveal, manage, or formalize it.

2.3. Unique Verbs/Actions

Project

People can partially or sometimes fully separate their soul from their body to explore the emotional space, commonly referred to as the astral plane. Projection allows them to enter shared dreamscapes, observe emotional wounds as physical distortions, and much more.

Bind

Two characters can undergo a temple ritual to magically entwine their souls. Binding amplifies emotional resonance between partners, allowing shared sensation, dream sharing, and empathic awareness. In gameplay terms, this can unlock cooperative abilities, synchronized magic, or shared perception mechanics.

Manifest

Emotional repression can literally become physical. Suppressed feelings and emotions can be both consciously and unconsciously formed into paranormal phenomena, turning grief into fog, anger into poltergeist activity, and longing into phantom doubles.

Sever

People can attempt to weaken or dissolve a soul bond through ritual confrontation. Severing requires reliving key memories and speaking out emotional truths. The choices and effort made by the person dictates the success of the ritual. A clean sever restores balance, while a failed sever creates lingering Echoes.

Reconcile

Instead of breaking a bond through the severing ritual, one may confront their incompatibility and reshape it into compatibility. Through mutual acknowledgement and vulnerability, they can realign

their soul threads, stabilizing manifestations. Reconciliation is difficult and requires cooperation. One-sided efforts cannot restore the balance.

2.4. Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Much of how this world differs from our own can be seen through Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs, as outlined below.

Basic Needs: Physiological

Food

Agriculture is influenced by emotional resonance. Crops grow best in emotionally stable households. Prolonged hauntings can spoil harvests or sour stored grain. Some regions cultivate "spirit touched" plants that glow faintly when soul energy is strong, making food both sustenance and a barometer of relational harmony.

Water

Flowing water is believed to stabilize drifting souls. Wells near temples are considered spiritually purer because consecrated ground prevents soul echo contamination. In areas where many Severings have failed, water may taste metallic or induce vivid dreams.

Transport

Long distance travel is complicated by soul tethering. Bound partners who travel too far apart from one another for too long may experience soul drag, fatigue, or involuntary dream sharing. As a result, trade routes often include temple waystations where bonds can be stabilized.

Reproduction

The fundamental way of choosing a partner and having children is different in the world, as normal sexual intercourse does not produce a baby. The two partners must conceive a soul for the child too by bonding with each other in the astral plane too. Only once both conceptions occur can a baby be made.

Basic Needs: Safety

Shelter

Houses and homes are typically constructed with a sort of spiritual structure in mind. Materials like silver thread mortar, consecrated wood, and circular floor plans help prevent poltergeist escalation. Bedrooms are often inscribed with protective sigils to prevent uncontrolled soul projection during sleep.

Clothing

Certain fabrics like silk threaded lined and rune-stitched cloaks ground the soul more firmly to the body. Temple priests wear garments embroidered with binding patterns that allow them to see soul threads.

Offense

Emotional instability can be weaponized. Skilled soul mages can manifest suppressed emotions into kinetic force. However, offensive soul magic risks destabilizing one's own bond, making combat inherently self sacrificing.

Defense

Protective magic focuses more on grounding and stabilization. Techniques anchor the soul to the body, reinforce bond integrity, or disperse hostile manifestations. Shields are less about blocking physical attacks and more about maintaining spiritual stability.

Psychological Needs: Belongingness and Love

Religion/Beliefs

Temples serve as both spiritual and relational institutions. The dominant belief system teaches that souls seek resonance and that incompatibility is not a sin, but rather misalignment. However, sects disagree about whether Severing is sacred or shameful.

Community

Communities are deeply aware of others' bonds. Public hauntings signal relationship fractures, making private issues communal knowledge. Neighbors often intervene before a bond destabilizes dangerously.

Family

Family units are defined by successful soul conception. Children are considered spiritual harmonies made manifest. Failed Severings that produce Echoes can complicate future family structures, creating tension in households.

Government

Governments regulate Binding rituals through temple oversight. Official records of bonds function similarly to marriage licenses. In some regions, unregistered relationships lack legal protection.

Psychological Needs: Esteem

Social Classes

Status is influenced by bond stability. Long, harmonious relationships are seen as spiritually prestigious. Individuals with multiple failed Severings may face social stigma, while temple clerics and skilled soul healers occupy respected positions.

Economics

The entire economy surrounds bond maintenance. Ritual services, dream interpreters, stabilization charms, soul tailored architecture, and Severing ceremonies all cost money.

Government Tiers

Higher political positions may require proven bond stability, as unstable leaders are seen as spiritually dangerous. Some rulers undergo public Binding ceremonies to demonstrate moral alignment.

Self-Fulfillment Needs: Arts + Cultures

Visual Arts

Many artists depict soul threads as luminous ribbons connecting figures. Public murals often commemorate legendary Bindings or tragic Severings. Some painters claim to capture the color of a person's soul resonance.

Language and Literature

The language has many words to describe the different stages of incompatibility. Poetry often uses haunting imagery to describe fading love.

Music

Duets are culturally significant, symbolizing the bond two people share. Certain musical intervals are believed to calm unstable bonds. Temple choirs perform “alignment hymns” during Binding rituals too.

Gameplay

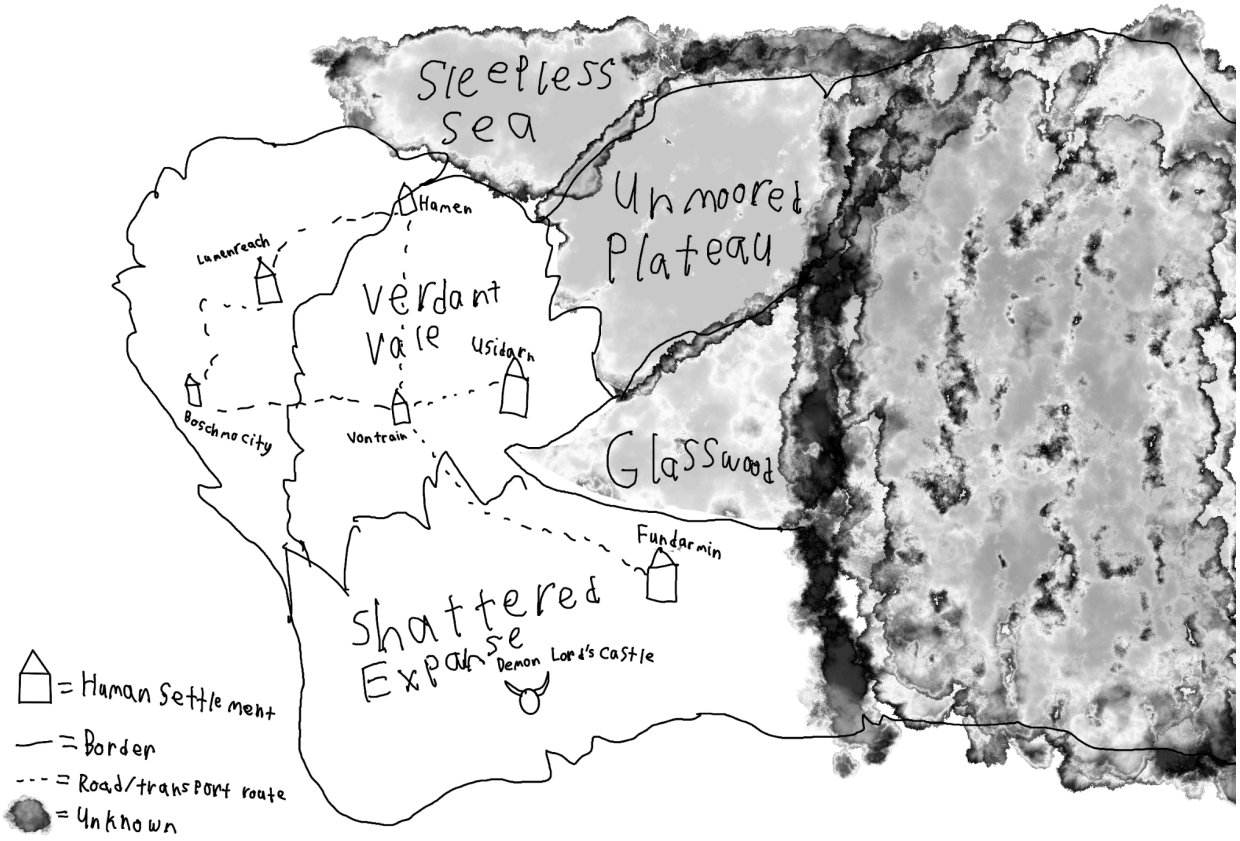
Games usually focus on emotional awareness and harmony. Children play cooperative games that require staying in sync in one way or another to “keep the spirits calm”. Older children practice guided dream challenges where they learn to recognize and resolve emotional conflict before it turns into a haunting. Play isn’t really about competition.

Self-Fulfillment Needs: Self-Actualization

Mastery

True mastery involves achieving conscious harmony between body and soul. Masters of soulcraft can project without destabilization, Sever cleanly without Echoes, or maintain a bond across great distances. However, mastery isn’t about control, but rather about emotional honesty and self knowledge.

2.5. Map



Key Locations

The City of Lumenreach (known to many as "The Threaded City")

The political, religious, and emotional epicenter of the continent.

Features/Characteristics

- The Grand Cathedral of Threads, where all official Bindings and Severings are performed
- The Public Severing Amphitheater, where high profile separations become civic events
- The Archive of Bonds, a massive repository of every registered relationship
- Known for its Temple Wells, whose water is believed to reflect emotional clarity

The Verdant Vale (aka the "Heartlands of Harmony")

Rolling agricultural lands where crops respond visibly to bond stability.

Features/Characteristics

- Spirit-touched glowing crops that glow when relationships are stable and dim when discord spreads
- Villages built in circular layouts to symbolize and reinforce balance
- Cooperative, harmony focused culture
- Often considered the emotional "heart" of the continent

The Shattered Expanse (aka "The Severed Scar")

A fractured wasteland formed by the catastrophic Severing of 351 AB.

Features/Characteristics

- Jagged black terrain with unstable astral conditions
- Areas where projection becomes unreliable or impossible
- Rumors of beings who feed on fractured bonds
- Home to the Shardbound and the domain of Astrael

Here There Be Dragons locations

The Sleepless Sea

An inland sea where dreams bleed into reality

Features/Characteristics

- Sailors report shared dreams across entire crews
- Long term exposure leads to hallucination, identity bleed, and emotional overlap

- No one knows what lies beneath

The Glasswood

A crystalline forest where the unresolved Echoes of the dead gather and repeat unresolved emotional fragments.

Features/Characteristics

- Trees refract soul light, distorting perception
- Voices can be heard repeating old arguments, confessions, and unfinished conversations
- The forest is slowly expanding as more people pass away with unresolved Echoes

The Unmoored Plateau

A highland where soul projection becomes dangerously easy.

Features/Characteristics

- People drift from their bodies unintentionally
- Time perception becomes inconsistent
- Long exposure leads to partial or permanent disconnection from the physical body

2.6. Timeline

AB stands for after binding and PB for pre-binding

The Official Temple Timeline (widely known and accepted as true)

553 PB	Unknown
347 PB	Unknown
0 AB	The Convergence. A celestial alignment triggers mass, involuntary soul projection across the continent. Entire cities fall into shared dream states. When they awaken, soul threads become visible to everyone for a short duration of time, causing people to begin studying resonance.

46 AB	Unknown
87 AB	The First Temple of Binding is founded in Lumenreach. Binding rituals are standardized and government recognized. Soul marks became legal identifiers of partnership.
134 AB	The Severing Rite is formally codified. Public Severings become culturally stigmatized as spiritual failure.
205 AB	Unknown
241 AB	The Echo Plague begins. Mishandled and politically motivated Severings leave behind thousands of Echoes. Agricultural collapse and regional hauntings cause mass displacement.
247 AB	Temple authority is nominally brought under governmental oversight after public outrage over the Echo Plague. In practice, the Temple retains control over Binding and Severing rituals, while governments regulate their legal consequences. Forced Severings are outlawed, but enforcement varies by region. Astral research is quickly restricted, though Temple sponsored research continues privately within the Restricted Archives..
302 AB	The Astral Cartographers attempt a synchronized deep plane projection. None return. Their bodies remain alive, but unresponsive. The event is declared a tragic miscalculation.
351 AB	The Southern Blacklands rupture. Projection fails entirely within a widening region of fractured terrain. Reports describe shadow distortions and inverted soul light. The area is officially declared spiritually contaminated and renamed The Shattered Expanse.
412(present day)	Echo sightings increase. Reports of shared dreams across cities suggest continental scale resonance instability. Temple archives deny any systemic threat.

The Hidden Timeline (known as the Restricted Archives)

1287 PB	An ancient text references something called “The Prime Bond”, described as a union between two cosmic entities whose resonance stabilized reality itself. (There is no official temple record of this)
3 PB	Records indicate that small scale soul projection existed long before The Convergence. These early projectors documented subtle “hairline fractures” in the astral sky, which are faint distortions where

	resonance felt doubled, as if two immense threads were pulling slightly out of alignment. All copies of these writings were later destroyed.
0 AB (Reclassified)	The Convergence wasn't entirely natural. Astral Cartographers' recovered fragments suggest the mass projection may have been triggered by the destabilization of something large enough to destabilize reality. That something would later be speculated as the Prime Bond destabilizing.
302 AB (Unredacted)	Before their disappearance, the Astral Cartographers reported encountering a presence beyond the mapped astral plane. They described it as "two threads violently separated but still entangled". Their final transmission references the name "Astrael". This name doesn't appear in any official archives.
351 AB (True Record)	The rupture in the Southern Blacklands wasn't spontaneous. It was a Severing. Researchers learned of the destabilized Prime Bond and came to the conclusion that instead of attempting to fix the bond, they should forcibly Sever the connection. Astrael, one half of the Prime Bond, was forcibly separated from her partner, but instead of simply disappearing like the researchers had believed, she instead became the entity now known as the Demon Lord. Astrael isn't a being of evil, but a living fragment of the incomplete cosmic Severing. Her domain destabilizes projection because her own bond was never cleanly cut.
Unknown date - present day	Resonance instability is increasing, not because of human incompatibility, but because something is attempting to rebind.

2.7. Character Types

Temple Resonants (Clerics of Binding)

Temple Resonants are formally trained regulators of soul binding and Severing. They oversee rituals, register bonds, and monitor resonance instability. They operate primarily from Lumenreach, but maintain outposts across the known continent

Abilities

- Conducting Binding and Severing rituals
- Detecting resonance instability in individuals
- Sensing lingering Echoes
- Project into the astral plane with high precision

Beliefs

- Emotional alignment must be acknowledged, not suppressed
- Incompatibility is spiritually dangerous
- Bonds must be regulated for social stability
- The Convergence was a divine revelation

Physical Characteristics

- Faint luminescent thread marks along wrists or sternum
- Eyes often slightly reflective in low light (due to projection training)
- Ritual scars from Severing ceremonies
- They wear layered garments woven with thread symbol embroidery

Vale Harmonists (Agrarian Bond Keepers)

Communities in the Verdant Vale who treat bonding as communal rather than bureaucratic. They rely on emotional honesty because their crops physically respond to resonance stability.

Abilities

- Subtle emotional attunement to group harmony
- Can sense discord before it manifests physically
- Some can encourage minor astral resonance in soil and seed
- Skilled in cooperative projection (small, shared dream states)

Beliefs

- Bonds are natural, not institutional
- Severing should be private and mutual
- Suppression causes rot both emotionally and agriculturally
- The temples overreach
- Instability is increasing, but not because of individual failure

Physical Characteristics

- Calloused hands marked by faint glowing crop pollen
- Sun warmed skin tones
- Soul marks often less defined but more organic in shape
- Wear circular or spiral motifs symbolizing balance

Shardbound (inhabitants of the Shattered Expanse)

Those who live near or within the Shattered Expanse. Many are descendants of survivors of the 351 AB rupture. They are often labeled “tainted” by the Temple.

Abilities

- Irregular projection, sometimes involuntary
- Can survive brief exposure to projection dead zones
- Some can perceive fractured astral spaces others can’t
- Increased resistance to Echo corruption

Beliefs

- The Temple caused the catastrophe
- The Demon Lord isn’t evil, but wronged
- Severing without consent is violence

- The world is destabilizing again

Physical Characteristics

- Darkened or fractured looking soul marks
- Eyes may reflect faint red or violet hues in astral light
- Veins occasionally glow during emotional stress
- Scarring from proximity to astral ruptures

Character Type Relationship Chart

	Temple Resonants	**Vale Harmonists**	**Shardbound**
Temple Resonants	Guardians of stability	Well meaning, but undisciplined	Unstable and potentially dangerous
Vale Harmonists	Rigid and political	Balanced and practical	Tragic victims
Shardbound	Bringers of catastrophe	Respect their emotional honesty, but think they are naive	Living proof of hidden truth

3. The Story

3.1. Simple-Story

Setup

In the present day (412 AB), resonance instability is increasing across the continent. Echo sightings are rising, shared dreams are spreading between cities, and the Temple archives publicly deny any systemic threat.

Act I

Joal is a young Temple Resonant stationed in Lumenreach, trained to regulate and stabilize bonds. They believe deeply in the Temple's doctrine: incompatibility is tragic but manageable through ritual honesty.

They are assigned to oversee a high-profile Severing between two influential citizens whose public hauntings are destabilizing an entire district. Crops are failing in nearby shipments from the Verdant Vale. Cold spots and phantom doubles appear nightly.

Joal wants to perform a clean Severing to not only restore stability, but to prove their competence.

Joal prepares the couple for Severing at the Grand Cathedral of Threads in Lumenreach. During preliminary projection into the astral plane, however, they discover something unusual: the couple's soul threads aren't merely fraying, but they appear to be entangled with something vast and distant. Public hauntings intensify. Shared dreams spread beyond the couple to neighbors who were never Bound to them.

A Shardbound outsider named Keith arrives uninvited at the cathedral's outer threshold. He claims this instability isn't local, but connected to something far older. Speaking bluntly and without deference to Temple protocol, Keith asserts that the Temple's Severing rituals are weakening reality itself, and hints that the rupture that created the Shattered Expanse was not natural, but was a forced Severing, a violation. Joal dismisses this as a heretical agitator and has him escorted out.

The act ends with a failed initial Severing attempt. Instead of a clean separation, a violent astral backlash sends shockwaves through the city, resulting in an Echo manifesting physically in the cathedral. In the chaos, Joal catches a glimpse of Keith watching from the archway, unsurprised.

Act II

The city enters partial lockdown as manifestations spread. The couple's incompatibility now triggers shared dreamstates across districts.

Joal, shaken and unable to explain the backlash through doctrine alone, reluctantly seeks out Keith. Keith agrees to speak only on his own terms, outside Temple walls, in an unmarked district. He reveals fragments of what he calls the hidden truth: the Southern Blacklands rupture in 351 AB was a forced Severing of something ancient and cosmic. He doesn't yet name it fully, but he warns that the threads Joal glimpsed in the astral plane aren't local.

Joal investigates in secret and uncovers Restricted Archive fragments referencing the Astral Cartographers, a presence described as "two threads violently separated but still entangled", and the name Astrael. Keith confirms what the archives obscure: Astrael isn't a demon lord by nature. She is one half of the Prime Bond, a cosmic union forcibly Severed by Temple aligned researchers. Her domain destabilizes projection not out of malice, but because her own bond was never cleanly resolved.

Projection sequences take Joal deeper into unstable astral regions. There, they briefly encounter something enormous: a fractured, cosmic-scale bond still trying to reconnect. Keith, projecting alongside them for the first time with reluctant cooperation, recognizes the pull immediately. He names it as Lost, the other half of the Prime Bond, withdrawing and drawing unstable bonds towards it simultaneously.

The couple's instability is just a symptom of the world itself trying to reconcile the ancient bond.

Joal realizes that Temple Severings might actually be contributing to continental instability if performed without full emotional truth.

The couple's bond begins to drag others' souls toward it. Soul drag spreads. Joal must choose between performing a forceful Severing to protect the city or attempting a reconciliation between the two, risking further destabilization.

Act III

Joal confronts the couple in the astral plane for a final ritual attempt. Keith remains at the boundary of the ritual space, grounding the projection and watching for fracture escalation.

Instead of pushing towards separation, Joal demands radical emotional honesty. The couple is forced to relive defining memories, not just of their love, but of subtle incompatibilities ignored for years. They reach mutual acknowledgement. Reconciliation isn't possible, but neither is denial. A clean, mutual Severing is performed. The manifestations collapse. The Echo dissipates instead of fragmenting. Most importantly, the district stabilizes.

However, during the ritual, Joal briefly sees beyond the local bond, seeing a colossal pair of threads in the distance, pulling on one another across fractured space. Keith, still anchored at the edge, sees Joal's expression and says nothing. He doesn't need to. They both know the local Severing was only the beginning.

3.2. Super-Story

Part One

In 412 AB, resonance instability begins rising across the continent with early signs including:

- Cold zones spreading through residential districts
- Poltergeist activity triggered by domestic arguments
- Phantom doubles appearing during moments of denial
- Crops in the Verdant Vale souring when communal harmony weakens
- Untrained citizens involuntarily projecting during emotional distress
- Minor demonic manifestations forming near failed Severings

The temple attributes these events to personal irresponsibility and increases regulation. Joal, stationed in Lumenreach, oversees a high-profile Severing whose instability spreads beyond the couple involved. During projection, Joal discovers that the soul threads are entangled with something vast and distant.

Keith arrives at the cathedral, uninvited, blunt, and undeterred by Temple authority. He insists the instability isn't individual failure but systemic consequence. Joal dismisses him initially. The failed Severing ritual produces a vio;ent Echo manifestation inside the cathedral, proving something is wrong that doctrine cannot explain. Shaken, Joal seeks Keith out. Their first real conversation is combative, with Keith accusing the Temple of repeating a centuries old crime and Joal accusing Keith of weaponizing tragedy for politics. But neither of them can walk away.

Although Joal ultimately guides the couple towards a clean, mutual Severing that stabilizes the district, they glimpse something far larger in the astral plane. They see colossal fractured threads pulling against one another from across the horizon.

The immediate crisis resolves, but the deeper fracture remains.

Part Two

Resonance instability spreads throughout the continent and emotional suppression begins producing large-scale manifestations:

- Entire neighborhoods experience recurring hauntings
- Long-standing incompatible relationships generate violent poltergeist storms
- Echoes gather in the Glasswood, forming collective astral entities
- The Sleepless Sea becomes permanently dream-active, with sailors experiencing waking hallucinations
- Spirit-touched crops in the Verdant Vale mutate or wither based on communal emotional strain

Projection becomes unstable:

- Skilled Resonants lose precision
- Soul drag intensifies across long distances
- Dead zones expand near the Shattered Expanse
- Some projectors fail to fully return to their bodies, reducing them to vegetative states or causing death

A Vale Harmonist going by the name Mendalie arrives from the Verdant Vale, sent by her community after the crop blight worsens beyond anything they've experienced. She doesn't come to the Temple, but rather to Joal directly, having heard through informal channels that a Resonant is asking questions the Temple won't answer. She and Keith distrust each other immediately. He sees her communal cooperative model as naive, while she sees his anger as destabilizing. However, both agree on one thing. The instability isn't personal failure. It's something else.

Inishi, Joal's former partner, reenters Joal's life under circumstances neither of them sought. A client couple she was privately guiding toward Severing began exhibiting the same anomalous thread entanglement Joal encountered in the cathedral. She reaches out not for reconciliation, but because she recognized the pattern and because she knows Joal's astral precision is one of the few things that might stabilize it. Their reunion is careful and difficult. She asks Joal a question they aren't ready to answer. Was their own Severing truly mutual, or was it just efficient?

As resonance instability intensifies continent wide, Astrael's ability to gravitationally contain demonic manifestations weakens. Demons begin slipping beyond the borders of the Shattered Expanse, not because she releases them, but because the fracture is widening faster than she can stabilize it. Keith recognizes this shift before anyone else. To his people, it is confirmation of everything they have always believed. The Shattered Expanse was never a contaminated zone. It was a wound being held together by the entity everyone else calls a monster.

Through the Restricted Archives and deep astral encounters, now conducted with Keith anchoring, Mendalie stabilizing emotional resonance across the group, and Inishi guiding Joal through their own suppressed history, the full picture emerges. The Southern Blacklands rupture wasn't natural.

The Prime Bond was forcibly Severed. Astrael is one half of that cosmic union. Her counterpart, Lost, still exists. The continent's instability is the aftershock of incomplete Severing. And finally, the Temple's long standing practice of regulating and accelerating Severings may have unintentionally worsened the cosmic fracture.

Part Three

- Manifestations escalate to continental scale
- Entire cities fall into synchronized projection states
- Soul threads become faintly visible to all
- Demonic breaches increase in frequency and scale
- Echoes merge into massive astral constructs
- Ritual magic fails unpredictably
- Binding marks flickers or destabilize
- The gravitational pull of the Prime Bond intensifies, drawing unstable bonds toward the astral fracture above the Shattered Expanse

Astrael can no longer contain the demons alone and the fracture widens. For the first time, she makes herself perceptible to projectors who enter the outer Expanse, not as an attack, but as a signal. Keith is the first to recognize it. He tells Joal that she isn't advancing. She's asking for help. Lost becomes increasingly forceful, triggering mass projection events across the entire continent. Its gravitational pull on unstable bonds accelerates, drawing souls toward the Shattered Expanse in waves. Inishi, working with Mendalie to stabilize projection anchor points, realizes Lost's compulsion weakens when incompatibility is directly acknowledged rather than suppressed or forced towards resolution. She brings this revelation to Joal, that the path forward is not control. It never was.

Mass voluntary projection occurs all across the continent for the first time in recorded history. Mendalie coordinates the anchor network across the Verdant Vale and beyond, her understanding of

communal resonance now operating at continental scale. Keith Guides Joal and the others into the deepest astral strata, to the Low Horizon, where Lost exists in fragmented grief and compulsion.

Joal stands at the center of the confrontation between Astrael and Lost.

Three paths exist:

1. Force rebinding to restore unity
2. Fully Sever the connection and risk annihilation
3. Allow voluntary confrontation without coercion

Joal refuses to repeat the original violence and decides on option 3.

Astrael and Lost acknowledge one another freely, with their incompatibility neither denied nor forcibly repaired. Inishi, anchored at the threshold of the Low Horizon, witnesses the moment and understands what she has been avoiding in her own history with Joal. It's not at the same scale, but the shape of it is the same.

The End

The prime Bond transforms and, instead of becoming a singular stabilizing union, becomes two independent cosmic anchors

The transformation ripples outward:

- Demons lose their gravitational dependence on fracture and dissipate or diminish in power
- Echoes cease forming from honest, mutual Severings
- Projection stabilizes across the continent
- Paranormal manifestations return to proportional scale
- The stigma surrounding Severing collapses
- The Temple is forced to redefine its role from regulator to guide

Keith's people are no longer labeled tainted, though Keith himself is under no illusion that institutional acknowledgement equals justice. He accepts it as a beginning. Mendalie returns to the Vale, where the first spirit touched crops since the blight began to glow again in the fields. Inishi and Joal speak again, but this time not about the cosmic resolution, but of their own. They don't reconcile, but they're finally honest.

3.3. Side-Stories

The Echo Keeper

Setting: The Glasswood, 408-412 AB (right before the simple story)

The side story follows a woman named Sera whose late husband's Echo has been haunting the Glasswood for four years following a failed Temple Severing. Sera isn't a Resonant or a mage. She's completely ordinary. Rather than fearing the Echo, she returns repeatedly to the Glasswood to speak with it, convinced that something unfinished remains between them.

The Temple warns her that Echoes are spiritually dangerous and insists the presence must eventually be ritually dissolved. Sera refuses. During her visits, the Echo repeats fragments of arguments from their marriage, distorted and incomplete, always ending at moments where Sera chose silence instead of honesty.

Over time, Sera begins to realize that the distortions correspond not to her husband's emotions, but to truths she herself never spoke. A young Glasswood ranger named Osse begins accompanying her and initially assumes she is projecting meaning onto something supernatural. However, he gradually becomes convinced the Echo is not merely haunting the forest, but attempting to complete an unresolved emotional pattern.

Eventually, Sera confronts the Echo and openly speaks every suppressed truth she avoided during their relationship. When she does, the Echo dissolves peacefully without the need for a Temple ritual. This is the first documented case of a natural Echo dissolution in the region.

Osse records the event and submits the report to the Temple archives. The record eventually finds its way into the Restricted Archives, flagged and buried.

Contribution to the Storyworld

This story introduces the audience to Echoes before they appear in the main narrative, allowing the audience to understand their emotional mechanics rather than seeing them only as supernatural hazards.

It also reframes the Temple's control of Severing rituals. The Temple claims ritual regulation exists for safety, but the buried record implies another motive: control over spiritual authority.

Because of this event, evidence exists within the world that emotional honesty alone can dissolve Echoes. This becomes crucial context for Inishi's understanding later in the main narrative.

The Binding Season

Setting: The Verdant Vale, 411 AB

This side story follows a Vale Harmonist community preparing for their annual Binding Season, a communal tradition where new couples undergo informal Binding ceremonies witnessed by the whole village rather than registered at a Temple. It centers on two young people, Tav and Renne, whose bond is celebrated by their community but who privately sense an incompatibility neither can name.

Tav and Renne agree to Bind during the Binding Season because it is expected, because they genuinely love each other, and because neither believes what they're feeling is serious enough to delay. The crops glow brightly. The village celebrates. Privately, Tav cannot sleep. Involuntary soul projection begins during sleep. It's mild at first, but then becomes disorienting. The village's communal dream circle picks up the disturbance but interprets it as pre-Binding nerves. Renne notices but follows the community's lead in soothing rather than examining. A visiting elder from a neighboring settlement recognizes the signs for what they are(early stage incompatibility manifesting before the Binding is even formalized) and is shut down immediately by the

community, who insist the couple simply needs time and support. When the crops in Tav and Renne's household plot begin to dim, the community can no longer deny that something is wrong. The pressure to resolve it privately and quickly, before it becomes visible at a communal level and reflects badly on the village, reveals the way communal harmony can curdle into communal control.

Tav and Renne decide not to Bind. They do this publicly, which is uncomfortable for the community, and without Temple involvement, which is uncomfortable for the Temple representatives passing through the village. The crops in their plot begin to stabilize and begin to glow again the following morning.

Contribution to the Storyworld

This story demonstrates how soul bonds influence the physical environment, reinforcing the idea that emotional compatibility is not merely symbolic but cosmologically real.

It also reveals the strengths and flaws of Mendalie's Harmonist culture. While the community values emotional unity, that same cultural pressure can discourage individuals from acknowledging incompatibility.

The story deepens the audience's understanding of why Mendalie believes strongly in communal emotional alignment while also hinting at how her worldview can fail when harmony becomes social pressure.

The Failed Severing

Setting: Lumenreach, 406 AB

Several years before the events of the simple story, a Temple-sanctioned Severing between two bonded partners begins to destabilize the city's resonance.

The couple, Arven and Lysa, were once considered a model Binding within the Temple community. Both were emotionally disciplined and deeply committed to maintaining stability through ritual practice. When their relationship began to fracture, they requested an official Severing rather than attempt reconciliation.

The ritual initially proceeds perfectly. Witnesses report no emotional turbulence and the resonance field around the Temple remains stable throughout the ceremony.

However, within days, small anomalies begin appearing throughout the city. Lantern flames dim unexpectedly, animals grow agitated, and several citizens report brief, involuntary dream projections.

Temple Resonants eventually discover that while the ritual technically severed the bond, neither Arven nor Lysa had confronted the unresolved resentment between them. Instead of forming a visible Echo, the unresolved emotional energy disperses throughout Lumenreach in subtle disturbances.

THe Temple quietly performs multiple stabilization rituals across the city and publicly attributes the disturbances to minor resonance fluctuations.

Arven and Lysa are reassigned to distant postings and the incident is removed from official records.

Contribution to the Storyworld

This story demonstrates that ritual Severing alone doesn't always resolve the emotional forces that Bonds create. Even technically perfect rituals can fail if the underlying truth remains unresolved.

It also reveals how the Temple manages instability not only through spiritual authority, but through information control, quietly containing incidents that could undermine public confidence in ritual regulation.

The event reinforces that resonance in this world responds primarily to genuine emotional states rather than procedural correctness.

4. Heroes

4.1. Joal

Background

Joal is a young Temple Resonant stationed in Lumenreach, trained in the formal regulation of Binding and Severing rituals. They were selected early for advanced projection training due to their unusual astral precision and emotional composure.

Several years before the simple and super stories, Joal underwent a sanctioned Binding with a fellow Resonant initiate. When incompatibility surfaced, Joal chose to pursue a clean, doctrinal Severing rather than attempt reconciliation. The ritual was technically flawless and publicly praised as an example of proper spiritual conduct.

However, the Severing, while clean, left Joal with an unspoken uncertainty. The bond didn't fragment and no Echo formed. The city remained stable, but emotionally, something unresolved lingered.

Joal has never fully examined whether the separation was mutual truth or just institutional compliance.

This unresolved fracture quietly mirrors the larger cosmic Severing that reshaped the continent.

Personality

Joal is disciplined, observant, and deeply principled. They believe in emotional honesty, but also in structure. They were trained to see instability as something to manage and prevent.

They aren't cruel or rigid by nature, but they default to regulation when faced with uncertainty. They trust ritual over impulse and doctrine over ambiguity.

Their greatest strength is composure under astral strain and their greatest vulnerability is mistaking control for care.

Desires

Before the main narrative, Joal's desires consist of proving themselves as a competent Temple Resonant, maintaining stability within the ever destabilizing world, and that the Temple's system is fundamentally just.

Over the course of the narrative, Joal's desires change to consist of understanding whether emotional truth can exist outside institutional control, reconciling their personal history with the emerging cosmic truth, and preventing reality from fracturing again without repeating the violence of forced Severing.

Abilities

- Highly precise astral projection, even in unstable environments
- Skilled in conducting both Binding and Severing rituals
- Acute sensitivity to resonance instability and Echo formation
- Capacity to anchor others during mass projection events

Weaknesses

- Tendency to prioritize systemic stability over individual emotional nuance
- Internalized belief that incompatibility must be resolved efficiently
- Avoidance of their own unresolved emotional history
- Fear that without regulation, chaos will prevail

Arc

Beginning:

- Believes stability is the most important thing
- Thinks emotional instability must be regulated
- Trusts the Temple's rituals and authority
- Sees Severing as a responsible, necessary act
- Equates control with care

- Avoids fully examining their own past Severing

End:

- No longer believes stability must be preserved at any cost
- Understands the difference between witnessing and enforcing
- Accepts that transformation can be healthier than preservation
- Is willing to sit in uncertainty instead of controlling it
- Believes the Temple must re-evaluate its authority and control
- Comes to terms with their own past Severing

5. Villains

5.1. Astrael (ASS-TRAY-EL)

Background

Astrael was once one half of the Prime Bond, an ancient cosmic union referenced in Restricted Archive texts dating back to 1287 PB. This union stabilized resonance across reality itself.

In 351 AB, Temple-aligned researchers learned of the destabilized Prime Bond and attempted a forced Severing, believing separation would prevent continental collapse. The ritual did not destroy Astrael, but instead split the cosmic bond incompletely.

Astrael became the being later labeled the Demon Lord.

The rupture that formed the Shattered Expanse wasn't a spontaneous disaster, but the wound left behind by that very Severing. Astrael's domain destabilizes projection because her own bond was never cleanly resolved.

Demons are not her creation, but are simply drawn to her fracture through resonance. She stabilizes them within her territory. Without her gravitational pull, they would disperse all across the continent unchecked.

Astrael does not see herself as a ruler of demons, but as a monument to violation.

Personality

Astrael is not wrathful or tyrannical

She is immense, restrained, and sorrowful

She embodies suppressed incompatibility. Not explosive anger, but unresolved grief

Where the Temple seek regulation and control, Astrael represents what happens when truth is forcibly denied

She does not seek conquest, but rather acknowledgement

Desires

- To understand why she was Severed without consent
- To stop being treated as a contamination
- To resolve the fracture of the Prime Bond, but not through coercion
- To prevent further forced Severings that echo her own

Abilities

- Gravitational resonance that draws fractured bonds and demons
- Stabilization of demonic entities within her domain
- Disruption of projection in regions near her fracture
- Influence over large-scale astral tides
- Ability to manifest partially within mass projection events

Weaknesses

- She cannot force rebinding without repeating the violence done to her
- Her power increases with emotional dishonesty across the continent
- Her existence depends on unresolved fracture
- If it came down to it, Astrael would risk destabilizing the entire continent if it meant resolving the Prime Bond without coercion

Arc

Beginning:

Astrael exists as a wound. She passively contains demons and endures mischaracterization as evil. She does not attempt communication

Middle:

As resonance instability spreads, she begins to exert greater pull. Not to destroy, but to force visibility. She believes the world must confront the original Severing.

End:

When Joal chooses voluntary confrontation instead of forced rebinding or annihilation, Astrael is finally acknowledged.

Once the Prime bond transforms into two independent cosmic anchors, Astrael shifts from a fractured entity to an autonomous stabilizing force.

5.2. Lost

Background

Lost is the other half of the Prime Bond. Unlike Astrael, Lost remained distant after the Severing. The Hidden Timeline tells of the Astral Cartographers encountering “two threads violently separated but still entangled”. Lost is the thread that withdrew into deeper astral strata.

Where Astrael became the embodiment of fracture, Lost became abstraction, a force of avoidance.

Over centuries, Lost’s resonance has pulled unstable bonds toward reunification attempts.This gravitational draw intensifies during mass projection events.

Lost exists in the deepest astral strata, beyond the mapped regions charted by the Astral Cartographers. This region is sometimes described in restricted fragments as the “Low Horizon”, where projection becomes directionless and gravity feels emotional rather than physical.

Lost experiences existence as fragmentation. Its memory of the Prime Bond is incomplete. Not erased, but distorted. It remembers unity more clearly than incompatibility. It feels the pull of Astrael constantly but interprets it as something that must be restored, not understood.

It isn’t alone exactly, but it certainly feels that way. Every unstable bond on the continent vibrates through it faintly, like distant echoes.

It doesn't see itself as a villain, but rather as unfinished.

Personality

Lost represents denial rather than grief. If Astrael embodies emotional wound, then Lost embodies refusal to confront it.

Lost isn't cruel, but deeply resistant. It fears acknowledgement because acknowledgement confirms incompatibility. It would rather rebind forcibly than risk separation.

When encountered in projection, Lost rarely forms a stable shape. Its presence flickers or diffuses when questioned directly about the original Severing. It shifts landscapes rather than answering questions.

When Lost actually does speak, its voice often overlaps with Astrael's resonance faintly, as if two tones are trying to resolve into one chord. This makes interactions unsettling and reinforces that Lost is still partially entangled.

Desires

- To restore the Prime Bond to its original unity
- To erase the fracture rather than understand it
- To end instability by undoing Severing entirely

Abilities

- Long-distance resonance pull across continents
- Amplification of soul drag phenomena
- Inducing synchronized mass projection
- Attraction of unstable bonds towards the Shattered Expanse
- Temporary merging of Echoes into large astral constructs
- Lost's power grows as fear of instability spreads

Weaknesses

- Cannot achieve true rebinding without Astrael's consent
- Relies on unresolved longing to fuel its pull
- If incompatibility is acknowledged, its compulsion weakens
- It cannot exist in its current form if the bond resolves honestly
- Lost is willing to override autonomy if it believes unity guarantees survival

Arc

Beginning:

Operates unconsciously as a gravitational instinct pulling reality toward reunification

Middle:

Becomes increasingly forceful as instability rises, triggering mass projection events

End:

Faced with voluntary confrontation instead of forced rebinding, Lost is forced to acknowledge incompatibility. Lost is able to finally move from denial to acceptance.

6. Allies

6.1. Keith (KEY-TH)

Background

Keith was born near the edge of the Shattered Expanse, in a settlement formed by the descendants of those displaced during the 351 AB rupture. Their community lives in proximity to projection dead zones and unstable astral fractures.

They grew up hearing oral stories that contradict the Official Temple Timeline. In their culture, the Demon Lord is not a tyrant, but a wronged being. Temple Severings are viewed with suspicion, especially those conducted without full emotional consent.

From a young age, Keith learned how to survive irregular projection events. He has worked as a guide for caravans skirting the Expanse and as a scout monitoring expanding fracture zones. He's proud of his resilience but carries anger towards how the Temple labels his people "tainted".

Personality

He's blunt, emotionally perceptive, and distrustful of centralized authority.

Alignment wise, he leans towards chaotic good, as he's deeply ethical, but resistant to institutional control.

He believes that forced Severing is violence, even if done with good intentions. He values emotional truth over order.

He speaks plainly, even in politically dangerous settings.

He challenges Joal directly rather than subtly.

He's quick to escalate confrontation if he senses suppression.

Desires

- To expose the Temple's role in the catastrophe of 351 AB
- To prevent another forced Severing at cosmic scale
- To protect the Shardbound from further stigma or containment

He is willing to destabilize Temple authority and risk arrest to bring the hidden truth to light. If forced to choose, he would betray the continent's political stability to protect his home settlement.

Abilities

- Perceive fractured astral spaces others cannot detect
- Survive brief exposure to projection dead zones
- Resist Echo corruption longer than most
- Perform irregular projection that allows access to unstable strata

Weaknesses

- Deep distrust of Temple Resonants, including Joal in the beginning
- Tendency to escalate conflict rather than negotiate
- Carries generational anger that clouds judgement
- If his community was threatened, he would abandon continental efforts without hesitation

Arc

Beginning:

He sees Joal as complicit in systemic harm. He also believes institutions cannot reform.

Middle:

He witnesses Joal question doctrine and resist forced Severing. He soon begins to see the distinction between system and individual.

End:

Keith shifts from oppositional critic to collaborative protector of the new balance. He learns that reform from within can be just as powerful as resistance from the outside.

6.2. Mendalie (MEN-DUH-LEE)

Background

Mendalie is a Vale Harmonist that comes from the Verdant Vale. Her village experienced crop blight during the recent surge in instability, watching glowing spirit-touched crops dim as communal tension grew.

She was trained informally within their community as a bond mediator rather than through Temple Schooling. In the Vale, reconciliation and mutual Severing are private, communal matters, not public spectacles.

She has served as a facilitator in shared dream circles and seasonal harmony rituals. She's proud of the Vale's cooperative traditions and skeptical of bureaucratic oversight from Lumenreach.

Personality

She is patient, grounded, and relationally intuitive.

She leans towards neutral good, prioritizing wellbeing over rules or rebellion.

She believes that suppression causes rot and that harmony must be maintained through honesty, not regulation.

She de-escalates arguments before they ignite.

She speaks in metaphors tied to soil and growth.

She avoids open confrontation unless absolutely necessary.

Desires

- To preserve the Vale's stability and prevent famine
- To demonstrate that communal honesty works much better than institutional force
- To prevent emotional suppression from spreading further

Abilities

- Subtle emotional attunement to group harmony
- Guide small cooperative projection states
- Encourage astral resonance in soil and seed
- Facilitate mutual acknowledgement during reconciliation attempts

Weaknesses

- Underestimates large scale astral threats
- Avoids confrontation to preserve harmony
- Hesitant to challenge authority directly
- Her desire to maintain peace can become passive avoidance

Arc

Beginning:

Believes local harmony is sufficient to counter instability

Middle:

Realizes the fracture is cosmic and cannot be resolved through village scale methods alone

End:

Helps coordinate continental voluntary projection during the final confrontation, expanding her belief in harmony from local to cosmic scale

6.3. Inishi (E-NEE-SHE)

Background

Joal's former Bound partner from an earlier, publicly celebrated Severing. She was raised in Lumenreach and trained as a Temple Resonant initiate alongside Joal.

Their Binding was sanctioned, and their Severing was executed flawlessly according to doctrine. No Echo formed. The ritual was cited as exemplary.

However, privately, she felt emotionally processed rather than witnessed. She began to question whether efficiency had replaced honesty.

After leaving formal Temple service, she now works as an independent dream interpreter and private Severing guide for couples seeking discretion.

Personality

Reflective, restrained, and emotionally perceptive

She leans lawful neutral, shifting towards neutral good, having once been deeply aligned with doctrine, although now prioritizing emotional nuance

She asks difficult questions gently rather than confrontationally

She avoids spectacles and prefers private conversations

She hesitates before reopening old wounds

Desires

- To understand whether their Severing with Joal was truly mutual
- To redefine what emotional honesty looks like outside Temple ritual structure
- To prevent others from repeating emotionally hollow Severings

She's willing to challenge Joal directly if it means confronting unresolved truth. If Joal were threatened, she would betray institutional stability to protect them.

Abilities

- Navigate defining memories during Severing rituals with precision
- Identify patterns of emotional suppression in couples
- Conduct stable mid-plane projection without formal Temple backing
- Anchor others during emotionally intense astral reliving sequences

Weaknesses

- Fear of reopening her own unresolved emotional history
- Self doubt regarding whether she misjudged her past bond
- Emotional restraint that can become avoidance
- She struggles to initiate confrontation with Joal despite knowing it's necessary

Arc

Beginning:

Avoids Joal and the Temple system, believing distance equals healing

Middle:

Re-enters Joal's life as instability mirrors their unresolved past. Forces honest dialogue about their Severing

End:

Becomes living proof that separation is not failure when rooted in truth. Her history with Joal becomes a model for transformed autonomy rather than broken attachment.

7. Organizations

7.1. The Temple of Binding (Temple Resonants)

The Temple of Binding is the central religious and governmental institution responsible for regulating all soul bonds across the continent. Headquartered in Lumenreach, the Temple oversees Binding rituals, Severing rituals, and maintains official records of all registered relationships.

Goal and Philosophy

The Temple believes that emotional instability is dangerous, not just personally, but cosmologically. Their core philosophy is that relationships must be regulated to maintain societal and spiritual stability.

They view incompatibility as inevitable, but something that must be managed through structured ritual and institutional oversight, rather than left to individuals.

Abilities/Specialization

Conduct official Binding and Severing rituals

Detect resonance instability and Echo formation

Perform precise astral projection

Stabilize large scale spiritual disturbances

Relationships with Other Organizations

Conflict with the Shardbound, since the Temple views them as unstable and dangerous

Tension with Vale Harmonists, as the Temple sees them as undisciplined and naive

Collaboration

During large scale crises, the Temple is forced to rely on both groups despite ideological differences

Characters in this Organization

Joal

Inishi(former member)

7.2. The Verdant Concord (Vale Harmonists)

The Verdant Concord is a loose network of agrarian communities in the Verdant Vale that practice communal emotional harmony rather than institutional regulation. They reject Temple authority in favor of collective responsibility.

Goal and Philosophy

They believe that emotional honesty, not control, is what sustains the world.

Their philosophy centers on the idea that relationships are natural systems, and forcing them into rigid structures causes more harm than good. Harmony must be maintained through openness, not authority.

Abilities/Specialization

Emotional attunement within groups

Early detection of relational discord

Cooperative dream projection

Influence over environment(especially with crops tied to emotional stability)

Relationships with Other Organizations

Conflict with the Temple, as they believe the Temple's rigid system causes suppression and long term instability

Mixed views of the Shardbound, since they sympathize with their suffering, but often see them as extreme or shaped by trauma

Collaboration

They provide grounding and large scale emotional stabilization during crises

Characters in Organization

Mendalie

7.3. The Shardbound Clans (Shardbound)

The Shardbound Clans are decentralized groups living in and around the Shattered Expanse. They are descendants of those affected by the catastrophic Severing event that created the region.

Goal and Philosophy

Their worldview centers around truth, consent, and the rejection of institutional control, even at the cost of instability.

Abilities/Specialization

Surviving and navigating unstable astral zones

Perceiving fractured or hidden aspects of the astral plane

Resistance to Echo corruption

Irregular projection that allows access to dangerous regions

Relationships with Other Organizations

Hostile towards the Temple, as they see them as the cause of the world's instability

Respect but disagree with Harmonists, as they value emotional honesty but see them as too passive or idealistic

Characters in this Organization

Keith

8. Places

8.1. Lumenreach (The Threaded City)

Lumenreach is the center of institutional power, where relationships are formalized, regulated, and recorded. It's a city built on the belief that emotional truth must be structured to prevent chaos.

Environment and Aesthetic

Tall cathedral spires, woven with glowing thread-like filaments, stretch into the sky. Bridges arc between districts like strands in a web.

Key Features/Locations

Grand Cathedral of Threads: Primary site of Binding and Severing rituals

Severing Amphitheater: Public ritual space where emotional collapse becomes spectacle

Archive of Bonds: Bureaucratic heart of the city, storing every recorded relationship

Narrative Function

Lumenreach represents control over emotion. It's where the story begins to question whether structure protects people or suppresses them.

Despite its image of stability, Lumenreach is one of the most unstable places in the world. The sheer density of unresolved emotional tension makes it a hotspot for large scale manifestations.

8.2. The Verdant Vale (Heartlands of Harmony)

The Verdant Vale is a vast, fertile region where emotional balance directly sustains the environment. Unlike Lumenreach's rigid systems, the Vale operates on the belief that truth and harmony should be lived, not enforced.

It's often romanticized as a pastoral ideal, but that image hides how delicate and demanding true harmony actually is.

Environment and Aesthetic

Rolling fields stretch endlessly, glowing softly with bioluminescent crops that respond to the emotional state of nearby communities. Rivers run clear and slow, reflecting not just the sky, but faint impressions of those who stand beside them.

Villages are arranged in circular formations, with homes facing inward towards shared communal spaces. No structure dominates another, reinforcing the idea of relational equality.

At dusk, the land visibly pulses with soft waves of light passing through fields like breath, syncing with the collective emotional state of the region.

Key Features/Locations

Emotionally Reactive Agriculture: Crops thrive when communities are honest and interconnected, but begin to dim, wither, or mutate when conflict is suppressed or denied

Communal Reflection Practices: Instead of formal Temple ritual, villages gather regularly to openly confront tensions before they can manifest physically

Resonant Waterways: Streams and wells subtly mirror emotional truth, being calm when harmony is real and distorted when something is being hidden

Narrative Function

The Verdant Vale represents authentic emotional balance, not control nor suppression, but continuous, uncomfortable honesty.

The Verdant Vale isn't peaceful because nothing goes wrong. It's peaceful because nothing is allowed to stay hidden.

8.3. The Shattered Expanse (The Severed Scar)

The Shattered Expanse is the physical manifestation of a cosmic mistake. It's the result of a forced Severing that was never truly completed.

Environment and Aesthetic

Blackened, jagged terrain stretches endlessly under a dim, fractured sky. Light bends unnaturally. Shadows don't match their sources. The air feels heavy, like something unfinished is pressing down on everything.

Key Features/Locations

Zones where projection fails entirely

Regions where distorted projection shows impossible geometry

Presence of Astrael, whose influence stabilizes and destabilizes simultaneously

Narrative Function

The Expanse represents forced emotional resolution, or what happens when separation is imposed instead of chosen.

The Expanse isn't a place of evil. It's a place of interrupted truth.

9. Artifacts

9.1. Notable Weapons

Threadbreaker Blade

A ritual dagger used during Severing ceremonies. Instead of cutting flesh, it severs soul threads in the astral plane.

It glows brighter when emotional truth is spoken

If used improperly, it creates Echoes instead of clean separation

Resonance Bow

A weapon that fires arrows made of condensed emotional energy.

Anger translates to explosive impact

Grief translates to a slow, draining effect

Love translates to a stabilization effect that heals the soul

Echo Lantern

A lantern used to detect Echoes. While not typically offensive, it can trap and release Echoes offensively.

Using it too much corrupts one's own soul

9.2. Notable Wearables

Threadwoven Cloaks

Worn by Temple Resonants

Embroidered with soul thread patterns

Lets them see soul threads visibly

Anchor Rings

Keeps souls tethered during projection

If one partner is unstable, the ring heats up

Very expensive, so not many people have them

Shardbound Veil

Worn by people in the Shattered Expanse

Protects against projection instability

Looks cracked/glass like

9.3. Items

Memory Vials

Contain condensed emotional memories

Used during Severing rituals to replay key moments

Can be addictive

Echo Seeds

Crystalized remnants of failed Severings

Can grow into full Echoes if not handled

Sometimes used illegally

9.4. Vehicles

Caravans of Tetherlight

Travel wagons lined with soul-stabilizing materials

Used for long distance travel so that people don't get soul drag

They aren't perfect, so they still must take stops at Temple waystations

10. Enemies

10.1. Resonance Demons

Resonance demons are large scale manifestations of accumulated emotional instability. Unlike Echo based entities, they are not tied to a single person or relationship, but instead form from widespread or repeated disruptions in the soul resonance system.

Behavior

- Gravitate towards regions of instability
- Intensify emotional conflict in nearby individuals
- Act unpredictably, ranging from passive distortion to active aggression

Abilities

- Warp environments and alter emotional perception
- Feed on instability to grow stronger
- Generate or attract lesser entities such as Echo Wraiths

Weaknesses

- Destabilized by large scale emotional resolution
- Cannot persist in areas of sustained harmony
- Often collapse if their source instability is resolved

Narrative Function

Represents systemic emotional breakdown and the consequences of unresolved conflict at scale.

10.2. Echo Wraiths

Echo wraiths are unstable remnants formed from incomplete or emotionally dishonest Severings. Unlike passive Echoes, these entities become active when unresolved emotional tension persists.

They appear as distorted humanoid silhouettes, often flickering or repeating fragments of past interactions.

Behavior

- Haunt individuals connected to their origin
- Repeat phrases or memories to provoke emotional reactions
- Linger in areas tied to unresolved relationships

Abilities

- Induce memory loops and hallucination-like experiences
- Distort perception of time and space
- Draw victims into shared emotional states

Weaknesses

- Destabilized by direct emotional acknowledgement
- Dissipate when underlying conflict is resolved
- Weaken in environments of emotional clarity

Narrative Function

Embodies the consequences of emotional avoidance and unresolved conflict.

10.3. Dream Drifters

Dream drifters are entities formed from prolonged shared dream states. They exist between identity and memory, often taking on incomplete or shifting forms.

Behavior

- Linger in dream heavy regions
- Mimic voices, appearances, or behaviors

- Blur the boundary between reality and dream

Abilities

- Induce disorientation and identity confusion
- Trap individuals in recursive dream loops
- Alter perceived reality

Weaknesses

- Destabilized by strong self awareness
- Lose cohesion when identity is firmly asserted
- Cannot persist outside dream influenced environments

Narrative Function

Explores themes of identity, perception, and the loss of self.

11. Sample Reference Materials

11.1. Games

Gris

Gris has dreamy, emotional storytelling through visuals and abstract grief

Journey

Journey has connection without words as well as emotional resonance between players

Spiritfarer

Spiritfarer deals with loss, relationships, and letting go

Hellblade

Hellblade demonstrates internal emotions manifesting as reality

11.2. Movies

Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind

It has breakup as a surreal internal experience

Annihilation

Has emotional and psychological states warping reality

The Fountain

Love exists across metaphysical planes

11.3. Television

The Leftovers

Has grief manifesting in weird, existential ways

Black Mirror

It has the concept of emotional consequences turned into systems

Arcane

Arcane has relationships driving world scale consequences

11.4. Books

His Dark Materials

Has souls externalized

The Night Circus

Has romantic magic systems and emotional atmosphere

The Stormlight Archive

There are bonds tied to emotional states

11.5. Comics

Saga

Has relationships in a fantasy setting with emotional weight

Sandman

Has dreams, metaphysics, and emotional symbolism

11.6. Music

Carrie and Lowell

Grief and intimacy vibe

Melodrama

Emotional highs and lows of relationships

NieR: Automata Soundtrack

Ethereal, existential, kinda spiritual sound

About the Author

Lillian Russell is a Games and Simulations student at Miami University, where she focuses on the technical and systemic design of interactive experiences. With a strong foundation in programming and game development tools, she approaches game creation with both a technical and creative mindset.

Rather than replicating existing models, she is particularly interested in analyzing established mechanics and reimagining them in ways that create new and distinctive player experiences.

In addition to her technical background, Lillian has experience in interactive fiction through Twine and Python based projects, as well as independent narrative writing. This combination allows her to design stories that are not only compelling on their own, but also structurally aligned with gameplay and player agency.

Lillian is particularly interested in developing narrative-driven, systems-based experiences that challenge expectations and explore new forms of storytelling across interactive media.